

PERSIAN PALACE

Nestled in the remote mountains of Iran is Persepolis, a grand ruined city that was once the ceremonial capital of the Persian Empire. This complex of palaces and temples may not have been occupied all year, but at the New Year, subjects visited from around the empire to pay tribute to the emperor.



Heart of an empire

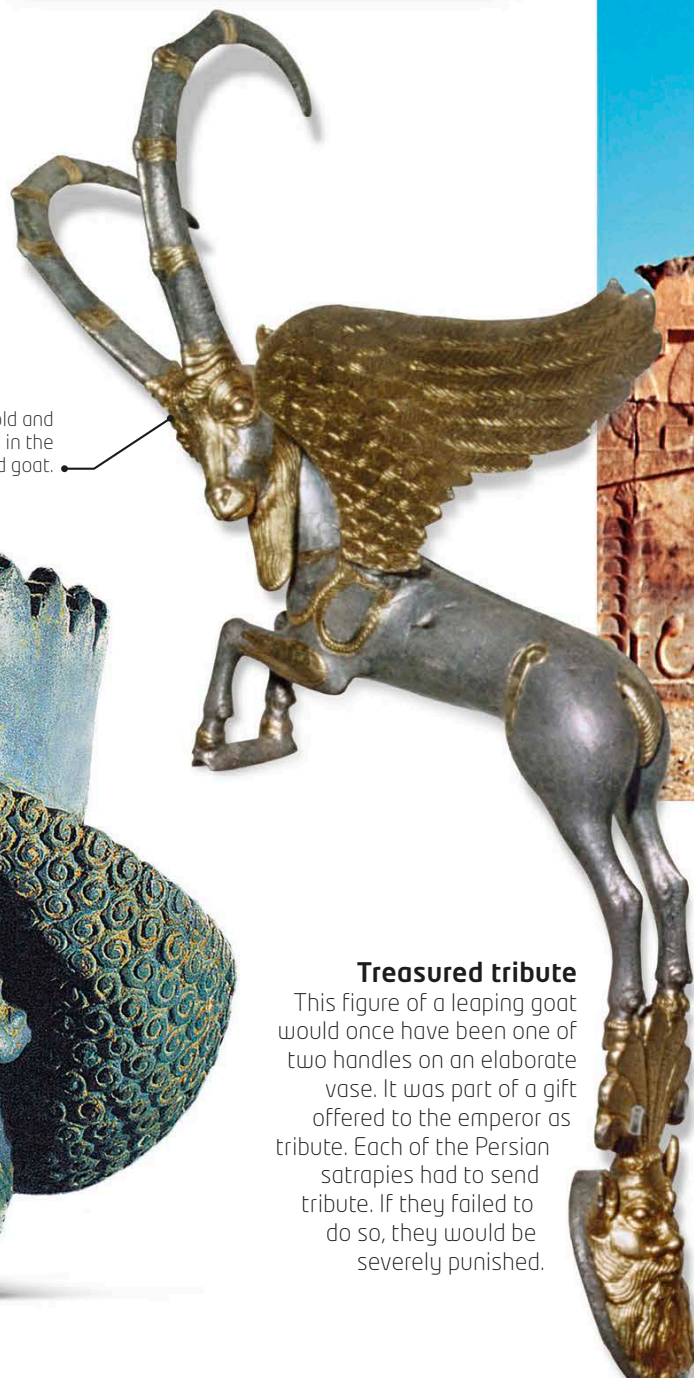
Persepolis was established near the center of the Persian Empire, in what is now Iran. The empire expanded from this area into eastern Europe and northwest India.



Darius I

Persepolis was founded by the Emperor Darius I in 518 BCE. He divided the Persian Empire into provinces called satrapies. Once a year each satrapy had to show their loyalty by sending valuable gifts to the emperor.

This ornate gold and silver metalwork is in the shape of a winged goat.



The swirling pattern represents the figure's curly hair.

This sculpture was made from lapis lazuli, a semiprecious stone prized for its intense blue color.

A royal head

This tiny figure is believed to show the head of a Persian queen or perhaps a young prince. It is one of the few artifacts to survive Alexander the Great's attack on Persepolis.



Treasured tribute

This figure of a leaping goat would once have been one of two handles on an elaborate vase. It was part of a gift offered to the emperor as tribute. Each of the Persian satrapies had to send tribute. If they failed to do so, they would be severely punished.